

Board 1

South Deals

None Vul

♠ 9 2
 ♥ J 9 7 6 2
 ♦ A 9 8 4 3
 ♣ 4

♠ K 10 8 7 4

♥ A 3

♦ 5 2

♣ A J 5 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ 5 3

♥ Q 10 8 4

♦ K Q J 10

♣ K 8 6

♠ A Q J 6

♥ K 5

♦ 7 6

♣ Q 10 9 7 3

West	North	East	South
			1 ♣
Pass	1 ♠	Pass	2 ♠
Pass	4 ♠		
All Pass			
4 ♠ by North			
Lead: ♦ K			

North is to play 4 ♠. East leads the ♦ K. West overtakes with the ♦ A and returns the ♣ 4.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=1 Total = 3

This looks like a walk in the park. If West has the ♣ K you can let that ♣ 4 ride around to dummy and end up making 12 tricks! What could go wrong?

What could go wrong is that East could win the ♣ K and return a ♣ which West ruffs. West could then play a ♦ back to East's ♦ Q, who could play another ♣ which West could again ruff. You could go down 2. That's what could go wrong.

Now, what should go right. Just because the lesson had many examples where you delayed pulling trumps, it is still true that **MOST OF THE TIME** you should pull trumps immediately. And this is one of those times.

So grab your ♣ A at trick 2, pull trumps no matter how many pulls it takes, then establish the ♣ s. The contract is cold.

For most suit contracts the immediate pulling of trumps should be the first priority.

Clear thinking is important, too. Can you imagine any Bridge player in the West seat overtaking his partner's opening lead just so he could then underlead his ♣ K into dummy's ♣ Q?

Board 2

West Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 10 2
♥ 6 2
♦ A 8 7 4
♣ 8 6 5 3

♠ 7
♥ A 8 5 4 3
♦ Q 10 3 2
♣ K 7 2

	N	
W		E
	S	

♠ A K J 9 6 3
♥ Q 10 7
♦ K 6
♣ A 9

♠ 8 5 4
♥ K J 9
♦ J 9 5
♣ Q J 10 4

West	North	East	South
Pass	Pass	1 ♠	Pass
2 ♠	Pass	4 ♠	

All Pass

4 ♠ by East

Lead: ♣Q

dummy will still have one ♠ left to ruff your ♥ loser.

East is to play 4 ♠. South leads the ♣Q.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=3 ♦=0 ♣=1 Total = 4

You can't help the ♣ loser, but the ♥ loser can be ruffed in dummy. The most important question right now is how many rounds of trumps to pull before you give up a ♥?

None would be the correct answer. Suppose you decide to go over to dummy with the ♠Q so as to lead a ♥ toward your ♥ Q 10 7. When South won the trick he would probably play another trump. Then when you gave up a second ♥ dummy's final trump might be removed.

Win the first trick and play a ♥ from your hand. If they play a ♠, win in your hand and play another ♥. If they play another ♠ it will be just the second and

At the first hint that you might be thinking of ruffing losers in dummy the defenders are going to start leading trumps to try to prevent you.

So you must stay a jump ahead of them. In this Deal the only way they could have gotten the jump on you would have been with a trump opening lead.

Board 3

South Deals

None Vul

♠ J 10 5
 ♥ 9 7
 ♦ 9 3 2
 ♣ K J 9 6 4

♠ 8 7 3 2

♥ A K

♦ J 8 6 4

♣ 7 5 3



♠ A 9 6
 ♥ 8 6 4
 ♦ K Q 10 7
 ♣ Q 10 8

♠ K Q 4

♥ Q J 10 5 3 2

♦ A 5

♣ A 2

West	North	East	South
			1 ♥
Pass	1NT	Pass	3 ♥
Pass	4 ♥		
All Pass			

4 ♥ by South

Lead: ♥ 7

Here there was no realistic hope of making this contract without playing twice toward your ♠ K Q.

South is to play 4 ♥. West leads the ♥ 7.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 4

You need to find East with the ♠ A to avoid two losers in the suit. But even if he has the card you must still be careful. You are in dummy right now, and you are only going to be in dummy once more.

Right now you must lead a ♠ toward your hand and put up the ♠ K when East plays low. When this wins the trick return to dummy with a trump and play another ♠ toward the ♠ Q. When this also wins you can pull trumps, not before.

It may go against the grain not to start pulling trumps immediately, but the urgency to remove the enemy trumps must be weighed against the best plan for the hand as a whole.

Board 4

West Deals

Both Vul

♠ 8

♥ K Q 5

♦ K J 9 8 5 2

♣ A 6 2

♠ J 6 5 2

♥ 10 8 4

♦ A 3

♣ 10 9 8 3



♠ K Q 7

♥ A 6 3

♦ Q 10 6 4

♣ Q J 5

♠ A 10 9 4 3

♥ J 9 7 2

♦ 7

♣ K 7 4

West

1♦

3♦

All Pass

5♦ by West

Lead: ♣10

Instead, win the first trick and immediately play your ♠ toward dummy's ♠ K Q. A defender will probably take this trick but you don't care. They will play another ♣ to try to set up a trick in the suit but you can win the ♣, enter dummy with the ♥A, and discard your "slow" ♣ loser on dummy's good ♠ honor.

And then, with that important job done, you can lead trumps.

Bridge is a game of timing, and sometimes the tempo of the game is set by the opening lead.

Suppose North's opening lead was a ♠, a ♥ or a ♦. You would have still had the same 3 losers, but now the ♣ loser would have been "very slow". So slow that you could start on trumps before working on the ♠s.

In other words, with one of these opening leads a mediocre player, one who had never read this lesson, would probably make the contract without any trouble. But with the ♣ lead only a skilled declarer would make it!

West is to play 5♦. North leads the ♣10. You play dummy's ♣J and South puts on the ♣K.

Losers: ♠=1 ♥=0 ♦=1 ♣=1 Total = 3

The ♠ loser and ♦ loser are "fast" losers, meaning your opponents can take them whenever they are in the lead. The ♣ loser is a "slow" loser, meaning you might have some time to dispose of it.

But here is the problem. If you start to draw trumps, a defender will take the ♦A and play another ♣, forcing out your ♣Q. Then, when you play a ♠ they will jump in with the ♠A and take their ♣ trick. Anything you can think of to do about that?

Once you recognize the problem, the solution is easier to see. Don't play trumps next!

Board 5

North Deals

N-S Vul

♠ Q 10 8 3 2

♥ J 9 7

♦ 10 6

♣ 8 7 3

♠ A K 6 5

♥ 8 3

♦ K J 7 3

♣ A K 5



♠ J 9

♥ Q 10 6 5

♦ Q 9 2

♣ J 10 9 4

♠ 7 4

♥ A K 4 2

♦ A 8 5 4

♣ Q 6 2

West	North	East	South
	1♦	Pass	1♥
Pass	1♠	Pass	3♦
Pass	4♣	Pass	4♥
Pass	6♦		
All Pass			

6♦ by North

Lead: ♣J

The 4♣ and 4♥ bids were control-showing. North is to play 6♦. East leads the ♣J.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 4

That loser count may be technically correct but actually it's wonky. As long as ♦s split 3-2 like they should you only have 1 loser in the suit. And if West has the ♦Q you can finesse and have no losers. Also, those 2 ♠ losers could be ruffed in dummy.

Suppose you tried it like this: Win the ♣, play ♦A, then a ♦ to the ♦J, then pull the last trump with your ♦K. That would only leave one trump in dummy for ruffing ♠ losers, but you could make the slam.

But suppose the ♦ finesse lost to East. And further suppose that East then played another ♦. Since only 1 ♠ could be ruffed you'd be down 1. Try something else.

Win the ♣. Play the ♦A and ♦K, forgetting about even trying the finesse. If the ♦Q falls that's good, but if it doesn't, no problem, just leave it out there. Then start on your other high cards. Take 2 more ♣s, 2 ♠s, and 2 ♥s. Then start cross-ruffing the last 4 ♠s and ♥s. The ♦Q guy can trump in whenever he likes but you will make 12 tricks.

This is the complete deal.

again to see what would have happened if you had finessed in trumps.

Suppose you had won the first ♣, then played ♦A and lost the ♦ finesse to East's ♦Q. East might have then played his last trump back to your ♦J and the hands would look like this.

You need the rest of the tricks but the best you can do now is to take the two high ♣s, the two high ♥s, the two high ♠s, one ♥ ruff in your hand and one ♠ ruff in dummy. Letting East pull that third round of trumps did you in.

This is how it would have looked if you had won the first ♣ trick, then just played the ♦A and ♦K, not trying the trump finesse.

Leaving the master trump out, you would now proceed to take your two high ♣s, two high ♥s and two high ♠s.

Needing just three more tricks, and with two trumps in each hand you just cross-ruff ♥s and ♠. East can ruff in with the ♦Q at some point but he cannot prevent you from winning at least three of your trumps separately.

Board 6

West Deals

E-W Vul

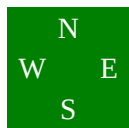
♠ A 8 2
♥ K 6 5
♦ K 4 2
♣ Q J 7 4

♠ 6

♥ A 8 7 2

♦ Q J 9 7

♣ 10 8 5 2



♠ K Q 9 7 4

♥ 9 4

♦ A 6 5

♣ A K 6

♠ J 10 5 3

♥ Q J 10 3

♦ 10 8 3

♣ 9 3

West	North	East	South
1 ♣	Pass	1 ♠	Pass
1NT	Pass	2 ♦	Pass
2 ♠	Pass	4 ♠	
All Pass			
4 ♠ by East			
Lead: ♥ Q			

East's 2 ♦ bid was New Minor Forcing, asking if West has 3 ♠s. West's 2 ♠ response said "Yes, I have." East is to play 4 ♠. South leads the ♥ Q.

Losers: ♠ = ? ♥ = 2 ♦ = 1 ♣ = 0 Total = 3?

If the ♠s split 3-2 as they should, you have no ♠ loser and your plan will merely be to pull trumps and play winners. So what you do in that case is start figuring how to deal with a 4-1 split.

But first you should deal with the ♥ K situation. Do you cover the ♥ Q or not?

Competent defenders do not underlead Aces at suit contracts. So if you are playing against a competent South you certainly don't cover. You play low on this trick and on the ♥ J continuation, hoping North started with a doubleton ♥ A. But he didn't, and he plays it on the third ♥ which you ruff.

Back to the Plan. Having ruffed the ♥ you are down to just 4 trumps in your hand. You play ♠ A, ♠ K, ♠ Q, noting that North discards on the second round. Therefore South will get a trump trick.

But don't give it to him now! Leave South with his master trump and switch to ♣s. If South doesn't ruff at all you will run 4 ♣ tricks and discard your ♦ loser. If he does decide to ruff it will be with a trick you were going to lose anyway. You win his return, ruffing a ♥ with the last trump, and continue playing ♣ and ♦ winners.

You can't help losing two ♥s and one ♠.

But you don't have to lose anything else as long as you don't lose trump control. So leave the master trump with South and just cash your minor suit winners. Let South ruff whenever he wants to because that will establish your ♠ 9 to control any more ♥ leads. If he decides not to ruff at all then he can have the final trick with his high trump.